

Chapter 117_2 - Explanation

After Han Ya left, Ning Fuyi pondered alone by the window for a moment before stepping out to return to the great hall where she had been earlier.

Just as she crossed the final stone bridge, a graceful white figure suddenly stood up beside the bridge. Ning Fuyi's steps paused briefly before she walked toward her as usual: "What are you crouching here for?"

"This slave was waiting for the Hall Master." Du Baishuang pressed her numb legs and stumbled toward Ning Fuyi. "The news from Flying Swallow Residence came through this slave's hands. This slave was worried the Hall Master might be anxious, so I waited here."

"I am somewhat worried, but Medical Immortal Jiang is clever and resourceful, and with the six sects searching for her whereabouts, she shouldn't be in mortal danger." Ning Fuyi spoke truthfully. "You may go now. Since you've been punished, return to Flying Swallow Residence tomorrow."

Du Baishuang nodded in agreement. Ning Fuyi brushed past her, but her palm felt something cool. Looking up, she saw a porcelain-white small medicine bottle.

"What is this?" Ning Fuyi turned the bottle in her hand.

"It's a pill refined from one of this slave's root tendrils¹. Though it can't bring the dead back to life, if there are any injuries or illnesses, one drink will cure them." Du Baishuang said, her black and white eyes clear.

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi tried to hand it back: "This is too precious. I don't need it."

"Hall Master." Du Baishuang stepped back a large step, avoiding her hand, lowering her head to let her hair cover her eyes and brows. "This slave has no particular skills, and my immortal power is also meager and weak. If not for the Hall Master keeping me, I wouldn't know how to live my days."

Seeing this, Ning Fuyi simply grabbed her five fingers with one hand and stuffed the bottle back into her palm with the other, saying: "I never keep useless people. You have an active mind and an approachable appearance - you're naturally suited for gathering information."

"So there's no need for thank-you gifts. Just do your assigned duties well." Ning Fuyi said with downcast eyes, then patted her hand and let go.

Not far away in the great hall, the door was slightly ajar, and clear pupils peered through the crack toward this direction. When Ning Fuyi pulled Du Baishuang close, those pupils contracted slightly.

Then the eyelashes lowered, disappearing into the door crack.

Having sent Du Baishuang away, Ning Fuyi opened the door on this side. Inside was the same as when she left - Chu Qingqiu sat sideways facing away from her, knees bent on the swing, her skirts trailing on the ground, looking very slender.

Ning Fuyi's heart relaxed. She walked to the stone table, her gaze sweeping over the cleaned table and the pastries placed on it: "Someone came?"

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her.

Ning Fuyi nodded and said no more. She waved her hand to conjure a chair and sat down, pulling over some papers placed nearby and began writing something.

In the end, it was Chu Qingqiu who spoke first. She glanced at Ning Fuyi from the corner of her eye and said: "So, what was the matter?"

"Jiang Li has disappeared." Ning Fuyi said indifferently, her brush tip still dancing. "She went missing on the day of the Demon Elimination Conference. A blood letter was delivered to the Jiang family, and outside must be in chaos now."

Chu Qingqiu frowned and turned around: "Jiang Li?"

"Yes, there probably isn't a second Jiang Li in the world." Ning Fuyi said. "You needn't worry. Now all the immortal sects are searching for her. I've already sent people to keep watch. If there's news, we'll know quickly."

"It's related to Penglai, isn't it?" Chu Qingqiu said.

"It seems so." Ning Fuyi said. "But I don't understand why Penglai would target Jiang Li. To lure me out? How can they be so certain I have a conscience and would act on this matter?"

Ning Fuyi smiled with pursed lips, put down her brush, folded the paper, and stuffed it into an envelope.

"Han Ya, deliver this letter to the head of the Jiang family." She spoke, and a small demon in black clothes immediately appeared behind her, taking the envelope and carefully glancing at Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu looked back, and Han Ya let out a "ga" sound, jumping behind Ning Fuyi to hide, not daring to show her head.

"What are you hiding for? It's not your first time seeing her." Ning Fuyi pushed her back out.

"She's the Divine Venerable, not Su Mo. I heard Divine Venerable Chu Ling has slain countless demons. I'm scared!" Han Ya's head was almost retracting into her neck.

"If you're scared, then hurry up." Ning Fuyi gave her a push, sending her into the darkness where she disappeared from sight.

Chu Qingqiu withdrew her gaze: "Who was just saying they had no conscience?"

Ning Fuyi glanced at her and said no more. Instead, she leaned back against her chair, took out the Divine-Demon Manual² from a prayer bead, and continued studying it intently.

Seeing that booklet, Chu Qingqiu's expression showed some surprise. She stepped forward to take it: "Where did you get this thing?"

"The Underworld." Ning Fuyi raised her hand to snatch it back, smiling: "How is it that the Divine Venerable is also being undignified now, stealing people's things?"

"What did you go to the Underworld for?" Chu Qingqiu's face reddened somewhat - clearly she was anxious, and her clear, bright eyes were tinged with anger.

"Nothing much, just listening to stories." Ning Fuyi turned a page of the booklet, studying the ancient text on it.

"You met Fengdu³, didn't you?" Chu Qingqiu reached out to grip her chair back, twisted her wrist, and Ning Fuyi's entire person was spun around, forced to face Chu Qingqiu.

"Yes." Ning Fuyi nodded. "But this matter is my private affair and has nothing to do with the Divine Venerable. You are neither my sect master nor my elder now. My every move presumably needs no reporting."

Chu Qingqiu looked at her, breathing increasingly rapidly: "Have you now completely severed ties with Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, completely refusing to let me manage you?"

"Since I have nothing to do with the Divine Venerable, why should the Divine Venerable manage me?" Ning Fuyi forcefully pulled the chair back and used her feet to turn around.

But just as she turned around, the chair beneath her was directly lifted by wind, so when she looked up again, she was facing Chu Qingqiu once more. She had no choice but to put down the booklet and look up to meet her gaze.

Chu Qingqiu was again angered enough by her that her face was pale as if she might faint, with only the red flush under her eyes like two red clouds, beautiful and blazing.

"I'm tired. I'll go find a subordinate to massage my shoulders." Ning Fuyi stopped meeting her gaze and stood to leave.

"Stop!" Chu Qingqiu said sternly.

Ning Fuyi stopped with her back to her, her rapid breathing no less than the woman behind her.

"Who are you going to find again?" Chu Qingqiu clenched her palms. "Who are you going to seek out to be intimate with you, to anger me with this?"

Ning Fuyi didn't speak. She knew the other person could surely see through her intentions: "I'm not this time. I'm truly tired. Chu Qingqiu."

The faint sound of sniffing arose. Ning Fuyi's heart softened, and she turned back to look at the woman with her back to her.

"Don't go." Chu Qingqiu said. She stood quietly under the lamplight, her voice hoarse.

"Do you know how jealous I am of Su Mo? Jealous that she wasn't born with that burden of responsibility on her shoulders, jealous that she didn't need to suppress her nature or cultivate the Heartless Way⁴, jealous that she could speak of love without any reservations."

"But Su Mo is you." Ning Fuyi said.

"She's the me I wanted to become." Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes and took out the jade hairpin from the mortal realm from her sleeve.

Ning Fuyi's heartstrings trembled slightly as she reached out to touch the jade hairpin: "Isn't this... I buried it in the grave when I left."

"I took it back." Chu Qingqiu said. "I originally wanted to keep some memories so I wouldn't miss you too much in the future, but I still can't do it."

Ning Fuyi looked at that jade hairpin, momentarily speechless.

"You should have unlocked the jade pendant I left behind and seen Ning Changfeng's memories. Those memories were left by her and me together. You also know about the curse."

Ning Fuyi nodded: "So the curse on me - you helped me break it. What was the price?"

"Half my cultivation." Chu Qingqiu said.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes tightly, turned her face to one side, her eyes stinging as she held back tears and smiled: "So your cultivation is only half remaining, your strength greatly reduced, because you broke the curse for me."

"My curse - I think you don't understand its meaning. 'Unable to cross the trials of emotion' doesn't mean I'm heartless and loveless, but that those who love me will surely die."

"Why didn't you tell me?" Ning Fuyi said in a low voice.

"If I told you, you definitely wouldn't be afraid." Chu Qingqiu sighed deeply. "You would only rush toward me like a moth to flame, regardless of your own fate."

Just as her words ended, she was pulled around by someone. The woman's young arms tightly bound her shoulders, back, and waist, as if wanting to press her into her heart.

"Ning..."

Her remaining words were all blocked by Ning Fuyi in her mouth. The woman's moist lips ground and turned on her lips, lacking the earlier aggression but being extremely gentle.

Chu Qingqiu's eyelashes trembled, and finally she resignedly raised her hand, gently stroking the back of the woman's head, trying to calm her sobbing tremors.

"Don't cry anymore." She said softly during a break in the kissing.

Footnotes

- ¹ **Root tendrils (根须)** - Referring to the spiritual essence or life force of a spirit clan member like Du Baishuang, which can be refined into powerful healing medicines.
- ² **Divine-Demon Manual (神魔诀)** - A cultivation manual containing techniques that bridge divine and demonic practices.
- ³ **Fengdu (酆都)** - In Chinese mythology, the ruler of the underworld/hell, also known as the King of Ghosts.
- ⁴ **Heartless Way (无情道)** - A cultivation path that requires practitioners to eliminate all emotions and attachments to achieve spiritual advancement.